

Standard Operating Procedure

ICU/HDU Admission, Discharge and Bed-Shortage Management

«Hospital Name» — Supports COP.9.b, COP.9.d

SOP No.	[Hospital to define]	Version	1.0
Effective Date	_____	Review Frequency	Annual, or on change
Prepared By	Quality Coordinator Name: _____ Signature: _____		
Approved By	Medical Superintendent Name: _____ Signature: _____		

1. Purpose

This SOP describes how «Hospital Name» applies defined criteria to admit, transfer, and discharge ICU/HDU patients, and manages the process safely when no bed is available.

2. Scope

Applies to every ICU and HDU admission, transfer, and discharge decision.

3. Responsibility

ICU/HDU In-Charge Doctor: applies the admission/discharge criteria and makes the bed-shortage decision.

Bed Management / Nursing Administration: tracks bed availability and coordinates the bed-shortage procedure.

4. Procedure

4.1 Admission, transfer, and discharge

1. Apply the hospital's defined physiologic and/or diagnostic criteria before admitting a patient to ICU/HDU.
2. Apply the same discipline to transfer-in and discharge/transfer-out decisions — these are not informal judgement calls.
3. Where a patient or family requests discharge against medical advice, follow the hospital's defined DAMA mechanism.

4.2 Bed-shortage management

1. When no ICU/HDU bed is available, follow the hospital's written bed-shortage procedure immediately — do not delay while searching informally.
2. Maintain ICU-level monitoring for the patient wherever they are held, until a bed becomes available.
3. Document the bed-shortage situation, the action taken, and the outcome.

5. Records

Supported by Records 2, 3, and 6 of the COP.9 Required Records pack.

6. Related Documents

- HCO_COP_9_v2_REWRITE_DRAFT — COP.9 policy

7. Review

Reviewed annually, and immediately after any adverse event linked to delayed ICU admission.

8. References

- Society of Critical Care Medicine. ICU Admission, Discharge, and Triage Guidelines: A Framework to Enhance Clinical Operations, Development of Institutional Policies, and Further Research. Critical Care Medicine, 2016;44(8):1553-1602. <https://www.sccm.org/clinical-resources/guidelines/guidelines/icu-admission,-discharge,-and-triage-guidelines>